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**RISHI SUNAK**
Prime Minister of Britain

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**Rishi Sunak made history by becoming the first Indian-origin PM of the UK, but he now needs to deliver**

By Kai Friese

Do you really need to ask? Rishi Sunak is a newsmaker in India because he's a proud kalawa-sporting desi who now runs (happy expletive) England! His appointment as Prime Minister of His Majesty's government in October prompted our majesty Amitabh Bachchan to quip "Jai Bharat... now the UK finally has a new viceroy as its Prime Minister from the Mother Country." Clumsy, certainly, a bit crude, perhaps, but come on...it's what we were all thinking. The Labour peer Paul Boateng expressed a similar joy from a different perspective: "Britain has shown the world that you can have a truly multi-racial democracy and it's something I've fought for all my life."

And yes, yes, he was born in Southampton to parents who came from West Punjab by way of East Africa. But the fact that Rishi Sunak sparks both Indic schadenfreude and egalitarian joy expresses some of the many contradictions that, currently at least, mark his significance as a distinctive world figure: A Thatcherite conservative who managed to come off as a *mensch* as Chancellor of the Exchequer during the pandemic, what with his 'Job Retention Scheme', Levelling Up and 'Eat out to Help Out' initiatives. A model of bootstraps immigrant meritocracy and plummy privilege (Westminster College, Oxford University, Narayana Murthy's son-in-law, a billionaire, the penthouse in Santa Monica). Similarly, as Britain's youngest PM since 1812, Sunak often seems raw and tone-deaf (his Christmas video asking a homeless man if he was in business was not his first brush with cringe-virality) but his heady rise in the hothouse of Brexit and BoJo has demonstrated keen ambition and a unlikely taste for the political knife fight. Two months into his prime ministership (already longer than his predecessor) Sunak faces plummeting popularity among Conservative party members and lags well behind Labour leader Keir Starmer in popularity polls. With a chronic cost-of-living crisis, and thorny issues of immigration, taxation and energy to deal with, Sunak has yet to prove that he is more than the sum of his intriguing contradictions. ■

**Buffeted by crises, Sunak's popularity is waning, but India rejoiced when he took over as British PM**